

Are Adults Better Foreign-Language-Learners Than Children?

(*Berlitz or Bust*) - original title
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Edited by Tim W. Ferguson, *Forbes Magazine*, 12.11.00

It remains a given in some quarters that English is the world's lingua franca and that fluency in foreign languages is growing less vital for American businesspeople.

Not true. Worldwide, people prefer to buy in their own language. The ever more multilingual Web increasingly means they can. No matter how good Hindi or Chinese speakers are in English when they sell to us, when we sell to *them* the deals will go to those who speak their languages.

<< Children are praised for less. Take an 8-year-old child to another country for three years, and what do you have? A fluent 11-year-old, not a fluent adult. >>

So the bad news is that U.S. executives need to learn a foreign (preferably Asian) language now — and well. The good news is that it's easier than you thought. Linguists are coming to believe that adults learn foreign languages more quickly and better than children.

The persistent folk belief that children are superior language-learners with "more flexible minds" traces to a 1967 pronouncement by German linguist Eric Lenneberg, called the "Critical-Period Hypothesis". He suggested children's brains have a critical period of openness to second languages, and if they don't learn enough by that age they will never be fluent in another tongue.

But even in those decades other researchers were finding the opposite. Among other studies, the younger-is-better idea was questioned in a 1975 testing of 17,000 British children learning French at school. A trio of academics found that, after five years of exposure, the pupils who began learning at age 11 outperformed those who started the language courses at age 8.

In the early 1990s University of Texas professor David Birdsong, editor of an influential new book on the critical-period hypothesis, changed sides in the

debate. Adherents of Lenneberg's original hypothesis are now having to defend an ever-narrower version.

I struggled at school near the bottom of the class in French, but at 27 started learning the reputedly difficult Hungarian language part-time. By age 30 I had paid translation work. I'm slow — I know other adult foreigners who went that distance with Hungarian in 12 months.

At the same time, I made a critical discovery. I started meeting "bilingual" speakers who had mixed parents and grew up in both the U.S. and Hungary. They're impressive at first — until you start finding their strange vocabulary or grammar gaps. Often apparent silver-tongued fluency is a skilful bluff, masking the fact they don't know how to translate words like "sparrow," "develop" or "architect."

The reason is that their foreign-language development took place at an age when they were too young to know or need such words. Take an 8-year-old child to another country for three years, and what do you have? A fluent 11-year-old, not a fluent adult. Truly fluent bilingual people who had childhood years abroad usually turn out to have learned most of the second language as adults.

One last-ditch defence of the critical-period hypothesis is the "Joseph Conrad Effect" – the finding that most adult learners never get the accent right. It is true that the Pole who became a great novelist in English (his fourth language) never lost his heavy native accent. And it's true that most adult learners fail in this area, although we should all be happy to fail as well as Conrad.

Pronunciation is a special challenge, but adult learners are so much quicker than children at everything else that it is secondary. And remember, almost all comedians who learn to impersonate famous people (a sharp test of pronunciation skills) acquired the trick as *adults*.

So why is the child-fluency myth so stubborn?

First, it's an excuse for not trying.

Second, we're deceived by trips abroad where the adults struggle with phrase books while the kids effortlessly start speaking, making parents proud. But children get praised for achieving much less, and they have vastly more time each day – unfettered by the adult responsibilities of trip-planning and being parents – to absorb the spoken language. A busy executive abroad who has the time to do even 100 hours of language study in their first year is very rare.

New research increasingly suggests adults are more efficient learners, more systematic and thorough. If we lose our stiffness and keep goals realistic, the crucial business languages of today – Arabic, Chinese, Hindi – will not be as daunting as they now seem.

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Edited by Tim W. Ferguson, *Forbes Magazine*,
12.11.00